FAMILY CARE FIRST | REACT

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2020 PARTNER SURVEY

REPORT ON KEY INFORMANT INTERVIEWS

USAID ជំនួយពីពលរដ្ឋអាមេរិក

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FAMILY CARE FIRST | REACT

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unleashing potential

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Executive Summary

The purpose of conducting key informant interviews (KII) with FCF|REACT network partners was to extend the findings of the third partner survey conducted in early 2021 and make recommendations on improvements to the implementation of the FCF|REACT initiative and related support mechanisms, approaches and systems. In addition to the subjects that were the focus of inquiry in the first two survey and interview processes, this year there were questions to cover how partners experienced and responded to issues arising from Covid-19. This new area of enquiry was focused on how Save the Children (SCI) was able to support partners as they adapted to unprecedented circumstances. Due to the difficulties arising from the Covid-19 situation there was some delay in conducting the survey and interviews, which meant that the period of inquiry was September 2019 to the time of interviews in February, effectively 16 months.

Methodology and Limitations

Interviews were conducted with 23 respondents from 12 funded partners, five representatives from non-funded partners who were randomly selected by the consultant, and one donor. This was less than the expected 36 respondents due to challenges in the timeframe for conducting the interviews. One respondent was inappropriately nominated by her organisation her responses needed to be excluded. The report is, therefore, based on the results of 28 interviews.

The questions asked (see Annex 1) were based on the tool used in the 2019 KIIs, plus the new section on Covid-19 issues. Adjustments were made to address the recommendations from the 2019 survey process to get feedback on the extent to which the recommendations had been implemented, as well as for key areas that required further follow-up from the 2020 online survey. Seven interviews were conducted in English by the lead consultant, and 22 were conducted in Khmer by Cambodian consultants. Three English language and one Khmer language interviews were conducted in person, all others utilised virtual platforms.

Respondents

Interviews were conducted with 21 Cambodians and 7 expatriates, 15 of whom were male, and 13 of whom were female, with the largest single group being male Khmer at 50% of the total. In terms of funding received directly from Save the Children, respondents from five partners receive only REACT support, four both FCF and REACT support, and three only FCF support. Two thirds of the respondents were based in Phnom Penh, with the others being equally spread across Battambang and Siem Reap. 78% of the partner respondents classified themselves as being technical/programme management level, with the remainder senior management staff at the Director level. There was one donor.

Covid-19 Impact – March 2020 onwards

Partners experienced many challenges during the Covid-19 period due to the precautions put in place by the government. The challenges fell under four main headings: direct impact on children and families; implementation: contact with children, families and communities; methods of working, communications and coordination; and, financial. The most common challenge, mentioned by every respondent was delayed activities. For many, working on the phone or online was the only possible solution, but that was less satisfactory than face-to-face contact for some needs, and in some cases it was not possible at all.

The list of solutions offered indicates a very strong level of flexibility, creativity and adaptability among the partner organisations. It also demonstrates strong commitment to keep working through circumstances that at times threw up barriers to getting things done. It is interesting to note that some points occur as both a challenge and a solution, particularly with regards to activities. Delaying meetings or community events was a solution for one aspect of the problem, i.e. following the rules for social safety and protection from the virus, which in turn became a challenge in terms of being able to move ahead with project activities.

(CCT staff raising awareness on COVID-19 in a community/ CCT)

Despite the large array of challenges that arose, the respondents were also able to identify what they saw as benefits that had arisen during this period. The most frequently mentioned positives were: understanding and use of technology; support from donors/ FCF|REACT/SCI; staff safety; improved collaboration with government; and improved staff attitudes. The support received from FCF|REACT, especially training, hygiene materials, communication media, and information were all very much appreciated.

Funded partners were especially appreciative of how FCF|REACT/SCI worked during this period and would want to see the same practices continue if the situation continues or worsens, in particular SCI being open and flexible, and working online for meetings, field visits and other activities, as well as deadline flexibility, mostly for reporting, but also sometimes activity flexibility. There were few comments offering suggestions of what should have been done differently, although there were two mentions of the additional data collection and reporting during this period being burdensome. Should the Covid-19 situation continue or worsen 26 of 28 respondents would want to see continuation of the support and information given already. Again, protective hygiene materials, information, posters, budget flexibility, capacity development and all other forms of practical support had many mentions. When asked if anything important was missing, there were few responses different to previous answers but some respondents emphasised needing more of something already in place, for example capacity development and information sharing.

Implementation period September 2019 – February 2020

Network engagement

Almost one third of the respondents have been involved since the start or early days of FCF|REACT, more than three years. Many of the funded partner respondents tended to focus their answers on engagement in relation to involvement in funding processes, which appears to indicate the high priority they give to the funding relationship relative to other means of engagement. Other activities with several mentions were learning summits, network meetings, workshops and training, and the Thematic Sub-Groups (TSGs).

(FCF|REACT Learning Summit in November 2019 / FCF|REACT)

When asked if their level of engagement has changed some respondents interpreted this as frequency. In this group there was an almost equally number of those with the same level or more engagement, but few said it had reduced. Of those who interpreted the question in terms of depth and quality of engagement, 15 respondents mentioned improvements in their understanding of the project and network, and their internal capacity to engage in activities. They cited learning from FCF|REACT activities, improved relationships, communications and collaboration among all partners. 11 respondents said they would not want to be more engaged in activities due time constraints or location. Those who said they would like to be more engaged in specific activities, offered a wide-ranging list, including more technical support on specific issues. A small majority of respondents, 16 in total, said that they would not want to be less engaged. Those that would like less engagement mentioned reducing data requirements and having fewer meetings and events.

Almost all the funded partner respondents noted positive impact from being engaged in the network, but some of them also mentioned negative impact. The most frequently cited positive impacts were improved staff capacity (multiple skills), learning from others in the network and strengthened systems. Negative impacts noted were compliance, workload for reporting, and SCI feedback mechanisms. The non-funded partners had very mixed views ranging from no benefits from their engagement, through to very positive results from Khmer staff being involved in training courses offered by FCF|REACT.

Funded partners only: Partnership with Save the Children

Many respondents listed the different type of contact they have with SCI and why. The majority felt the frequency of contact was about right with many positive comments about it. However, some respondents differentiated their assessment between different parts of SCI, i.e. technical support for implementation versus dealings with finance and M&E over reporting and compliance. 12 respondents did not want any increase in frequency of contact. Those that did want an increase made a number of suggestions about what they wanted. While 11 respondents said there was nothing that needed to be decreased, the remaining 12 had suggestions for what they would like to see reduced. When asked if they would like to have any new types of contact the majority of respondents suggested new subjects to be addressed within existing types of contact such as meetings and capacity development activities. There were two comments that there used to be a newsletter and it would be useful to have that reinstated.

The respondents all noted positive aspects of the funding partnership with SCI. The most commonly mentioned benefit was the support for capacity development that helps to strengthen them in various ways, both for implementation practice and in their internal functioning. The overall response was that partners want these positive practices to continue.

While five respondents said they did not see any challenges in the partnership, a majority of 18 did, as noted in response to other questions. These challenges fall into groups under the headings of SCI staff turnover, time/deadline issues, feedback on reports, SCI inflexibility and M&E issues. There were some solutions offered to mitigate the challenges. Respondents were asked if SCI staff were respectful, helpful, capable, and quick and fair in problem solving. The majority gave very positive answers for the first three criteria, but for the fourth point seven respondents said that there were time delays in dealing with problems, and another two mentioned unfairness in funding decisions.

The majority of changes in support noted by respondents were positive, in relation to what they perceived to be improvements in their internal capacity as a result. The most noted positive was about improved (clearer) documentation and systems for donor compliance, M&E tools and implementation procedures. The only comments made about the future were to the effect that these positive changes should continue.

Ability to contribute and participate: all partners

All except one respondent gave positive answers about their ability to contribute to and participate in the network fully or substantively. Those who gave qualified answers mentioned time and language factors as constraints. By far the most important reason given about why respondents found engagement positive was the learning and capacity development that came from sharing experiences and information together. Ten respondents said they did not have any challenges in contributing or participating. For the others the challenges noted were many and varied. The most significant suggestions offered for overcoming the challenges were to have more of the meetings in Khmer and to have more efficient meeting planning.

When asked about the extent to which the network draws on its members the majority of answers reiterated what members view as being of value about the network and why. A few commented on how they had contributed, for example the promising practices review. None of the Cambodian respondents commented on the extent to which the network draws on its members. However, expatriates did offer some comments, noting missed opportunities or never being asked to contribute anything.

Asked if they or their organisation received information and support that was useful, all respondents answered yes. They mentioned multiple means of communication all of which were generally regarded as satisfactory. Over half of the respondents said that nothing more is needed. There were some requests for more information and support, but they were all individual issues and nothing emerged as a strong theme.

Organizational support, best practices and challenges

All, except two unfunded partner respondents, noted multiple types of technical support they have received from FCF|REACT. The most frequently mentioned were: M&E systems and tools; case management; child protection and safeguarding; financial management; and, staff/social worker supervision. When asked what they would need in future the answers were primarily about continuing with the same areas of support.

The previous survey made recommendations about: meetings (location, management, translation); learning activities; finance team improved communications and problem solving; limiting changes to M&E indicators; ensuring members/partners have knowledge of others; partners having a capacity development plan; and, fostering interpersonal relationships. Very few respondents thought that everything had been implemented, the general view is that there has been some progress on the recommendations, but they are not yet fully implemented. There were suggestions that there should be regular reviews at every FCF|REACT meeting, and also in meetings between SCI staff and individual partner organisations, because the plans are sometimes in place but not being actioned. Several mentioned the need to refresh understanding of what is set out in the partner agreement.

Recommendations

The respondents were asked to make recommendations for going forward. They had many suggestions related to all the issues covered in the survey, and beyond as. Those recommendations frequently mentioned were:

Network relationships

- Remind all members of the goals of the network and take action with inactive members. Add objectives into the framework about process, not only product, to really make the network and collaboration the key issue as this is essential for long term sustainability.
- Map the members and identify their strengths in order to ensure they have a stronger voice at national level and also their potential to contribute and support others.

Learning and capacity development mechanisms

- Continue assessing, encouraging and strengthening the capacity of partners through the existing mechanisms like learning summits and exchange visits.

Communications, meetings and other information issues

- Improve meeting efficiency and shift the focus in meetings to contributions from Khmer staff.
- Have events, learning summits, etc. rotate around the provinces, not always in Phnom Penh, to enhance the engagement of local authorities and connect local partners.
- Provide more general transparency and information sharing about the overall achievements of FCF|REACT.

FCF|REACT/SCI - partner relationships

- Allow/continue some flexibility for implementation, reporting and budgeting, don't stick so strictly to policy.
- Improve transparency generally, and specifically about partner selection and decision making about who receives funding.

Project implementation

- Continue providing both technical and finance support to partners.

Introduction to the survey

Background

This report on key informant interviews (KII) conducted in 2021 contributes to the data that has been gathered about performance of the FCF|REACT network, and Save the Children (SCI) as the lead implementing agency, since the network was founded in 2016. The first survey was administered in late 2017 to elicit feedback from the FCF[1] network. Its purpose was to assess and improve the process of implementing the FCF network and provide insights on how the network needs to adapt to be more effective. This was followed in early 2018 by the DEPA-MERL process, which conducted a series of KII, among other activities, to assess the roles and responsibilities of the FCF facilitation partners (SCI and Global Alliance for Children (GAC)), as well as recommend actions for FCF donors' consideration as they continued to develop and implement the initiative.

In late 2018, Save the Children started preparations to implement a follow-up process to assess the implementation of the FCF network, the extent to which previous survey/DEPA-MERL findings had been implemented, and further reflect on how the network could adapt to be more effective. The FCF Knowledge Sharing Group (KSG) was engaged to provide direction on the partner feedback mechanism that should be used. This group recommended that a mixed-methods approach be used, including both an online survey and then key informant interviews. The online survey administration and analysis was led by FCF, with support from the KSG. The by KII were led an independent consultant, with support from FCF and the KSG.

(The 9th KSG meeting held in February 2020 semi-online / FCF|REACT)

The intention was to conduct the same process again one year later, in early 2020. However, due to a number of factors, most notably the very extensive amount of work produced for all in responding to the Covid-19 pandemic situation and challenges in hiring a consultant to undertake the process, there was a delay in commissioning the data gathering process. The online survey was administered by SCI in January 2021 and the independent consultant conducted the KII process in February 2021. This has resulted in two separate reports.

[1] Prior to 2019, this network was known as Family Care First (FCF). Following the introduction of EU funding in 2019, it was rebranded as FCF|REACT.

The objective of conducting KIIs with partner staff was to further explore the findings of the third partner survey and make recommendations on improvements to the implementation of the FCF|REACT initiative and the functioning of the support mechanisms, approaches and systems that underlie it.

It is important to note that this enquiry process covered not only a longer period of time than the previous survey, i.e. 16 months rather than a year but it also covered an unprecedented period of change in activities as the entire country needed to follow government guidance on how to protect the nation from the Covid-19 pandemic. For virtually every organisation involved this necessitated changes to, or cancellation of, their planned activities, and the need to put in place emergency responses for families in need. For this reason an additional set of questions were added to both the online survey and KII tool, to capture important information about how the network was able to respond.

Methodology

The intention was to conduct KIIs with representatives of the 13 funded partners, each of which were asked to nominate one respondent in senior management and one at the technical/operational level. As per the methodology applied in the previous KII process, the intention was also to conduct a further 10 interviews with representatives of non-funded partners (members) that had been classified as: (1) former GAC partners/members; (2) SCI partners/members part of initial proposal (longer-term members); (3) SCI partners/members who applied for membership (shorter-term members); (4) global members (outside of Cambodia); and (5) donors. The consultant randomly selected organizations to participate in the key informant interviews from each of these groups. These organizations were then asked to nominate an interviewee from their organization who is on the FCF|REACT mailing list to participate in the interview. The expectation was, therefore, that a total of 36 interviews would be conducted. The actual number of interviews conducted was 29, although only 28 were included in the analysis for this report, for reasons explained below in Limitations. These were 23 interviewees from 12 funded partners, comprised of 2 respondents each from 11 partners, and 1 respondent from 1 partner. Additionally there were interviews with five unfunded network members (4 of which are included in the analysis), and one donor.

The questions asked were substantively based on the tool used in the 2019 KIIs. However, a completely new section was introduced to cover the Covid-19 period, March 2020 onwards. Other adjustments were made to address the recommendations that came out of the 2019 survey/KII process to get feedback on the extent to which the recommendations had been implemented, as well as for key areas that required further follow-up from the 2020 online survey. The English version was reviewed by the KSG, who made some small revisions. When the revisions were finalised the questionnaire was translated into Khmer.

The agreed schedule for conducting the interviews was the period 8 – 19 February 2021. Seven interviews were conducted in English by the lead consultant, and 22 were conducted in Khmer by Cambodian consultants. Three English language and one Khmer language interviews were conducted in person, all others utilised virtual platforms such as MS Team, Google Meet, Zoom or Skype.

Limitations

The timeframe for organising the interviews was very tight. Some participants nominated by their organisations were slow in responding to requests for meetings, which meant that two interviews had to be conducted after the dates agreed in the schedule for completion of the work. Some nominated participants did not respond at all despite several follow up reminders, including one funded partner. One non-funded partner responded very late that they did not feel they had anything to offer. A substitute was approached but did not respond.

As noted above, the request sent to organisations to nominate interviewees was very specific that the nominated people should have some level of direct involvement with the network. However, one unfunded partner nominated a manager who had no knowledge of FCF|REACT at all, who therefore answered ‘Don’t

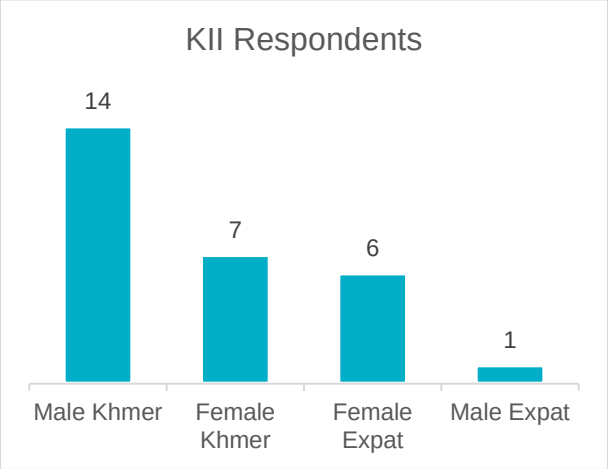
know' to every question. These responses have been excluded due to the invalidity of the nomination. The analysis is, therefore, of 28 interviews.

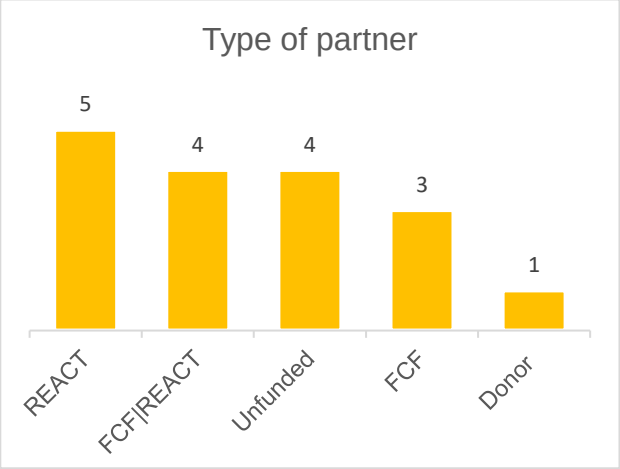
A further challenge was that there was no adaptation of the questionnaire for the donor interview. This meant that some questions were not relevant for the respondent, and other questions that could have been helpful to explore were not asked.

Respondents were not asked if they had completed the online survey. One commented that they had done it, another that they had not done it. Whether or not any others did complete it is unknown, so it is not possible to know the extent of the overlap between the two processes.

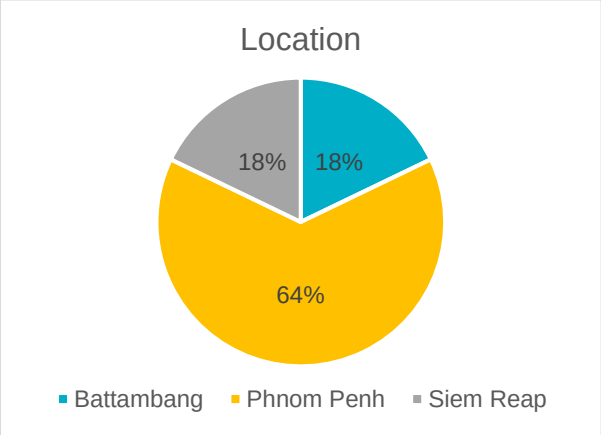
KII respondents

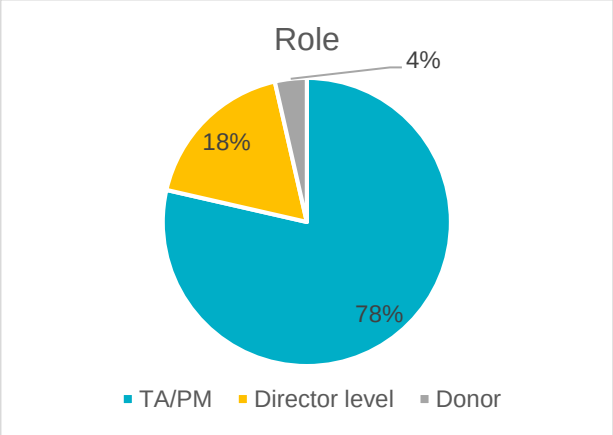
The charts below provide a summary of key information about the respondents. Cambodians were 75% of the respondents, with the largest single group being male Khmer at 50% of the total. In terms of type of Save the Children directly-funded partner represented by KII respondents, those funded only by REACT were the largest group with 5 organisations represented in the interviews, but organizations with both FCF and REACT funding was only one less. There were also four unfunded partners represented.





Two thirds of the respondents were based in Phnom Penh, with the others being equally spread across Battambang and Siem Reap. However, one of the Battambang based expatriate respondents was outside the country at the time of the interview. 78% of the partner respondents classified themselves as being technical/programme management level, with the remainder senior management staff at the Director level. There was one donor.





Section 1: Covid-19 Impact – March 2020 onwards

1.1 Major challenges arising and how they were addressed

The respondents noted an extensive list of challenges arising during the Covid-19 period. Of all that were asked in the interviews, this question generated by far the highest level of information. For ease of review the lengthy list of answers from the respondents has been organised into subject themes. The table below sets out challenges and the solutions to them under the headings:

- Direct impact on children and families;
- Implementation: contact with children, families and communities;
- Methods of working, communications and coordination; and,
- Financial.

While clearly there is overlap between some of these themes, the different points have been placed under the heading where they have the most relevance, and in some cases they are in more than one section because of nuanced differences. For example, working with local authorities is important both for casework with individual families, and for dissemination of Covid-19 information and materials.

The exact matching of solutions to challenges in the table below is not possible for a number of reasons:

- The questions were organised to ask about challenges first, then solutions, so respondents did not necessarily give answers that were a precise match between the two;
- Some respondents listed multiple challenges in detail, but few solutions;
- Some did not find solutions for some of the challenges they noted, for example children not being able to study online because they did not have IT access; and,
- Some listed few challenges, but gave longer lists of solutions, i.e. multiple points about how they dealt with one challenge.

It is interesting to note that some points occur as both a challenge and a solution. In particular this occurs with regards to planned activities. Having to delay meetings or community events was a solution for one aspect of the problem, i.e. following the rules for social safety and protection from the virus, and in turn became a challenge in terms of being able to move ahead with project activities. Delayed activities were by far the most common challenge, mentioned in one way or another by every respondent. For many challenges working on the phone or online was the only possible solution, but that also presented challenges as being less satisfactory than face-to-face contact for some needs, and in some cases it was not possible at all.

The list of solutions offered indicates a very strong level of flexibility, creativity and adaptability among the partner organisations. It also demonstrates strong commitment to keep working through circumstances that at times threw up a lot of barriers to getting things done.

Challenges	Solutions
Direct impact on children and families	

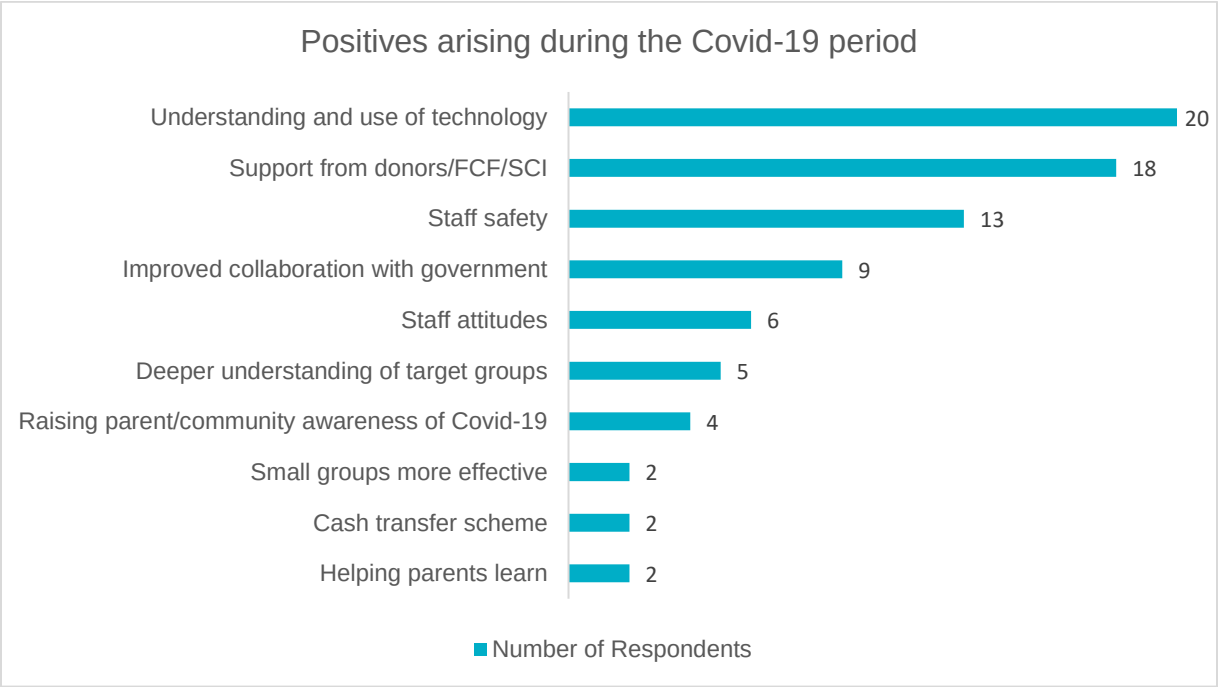
- Cancel or postpone child reintegration
- School drop-out and child labour, finding jobs to support their families
- Increased levels of:
  o Child abuse in families
  o Sexual abuse
  o Domestic violence
- Some children cannot learn online because they have no IT access
- Delay receiving the children from Angkor and Kantha Bopha Hospitals for reintegration into foster care
	- Worked with local authorities to help monitor and follow up vulnerable children and target families
	- Conducted survey/needs assessment with target families then provided some support relevant to their needs
	- Found more time to work with children
	- Contacted and followed up with children by phone call
	- Conducted additional risk assessments
	- Conducted 25 cases of emergency re-integration
	- Went into the field 24/7 to identify and respond to families' needs

Challenges	Solutions
- Projects, including centres providing services, had to close	- For an after-school project that had to close, teachers switched to in-home teaching - Provided different types of support, e.g. rice delivered to homes.
Implementation: Contact with children, families and communities	
- Delay/postpone/reduce activities with and support for children and families - Delay/postpone activities with authorities - Delay/cancel community/group activities - Switch from large to small group activities - Not able to work face to face and phone/online contact difficult, unsatisfactory or not possible - Unable to follow standard procedures, like reviews and case management - Beneficiaries unable or unwilling to participate in meetings - Number of clients increased, so difficult to support them - Government did not allow travel between districts - Need to make clients aware of Covid-19 and the necessary protections	- Field visit for some urgent protection cases (following MoH guidelines) - Staff travelled to province/communities to understand and assess needs in order to request support - Increased levels of cooperation with local authorities to distribute hygiene materials and food supplies - Working by phone or online with target group in multiple ways, including counselling and case management - Separated participants to attend smaller meetings or training events according to MoH guidelines - Multiple group activities such as training and awareness raising conducted online (but this also difficult with big numbers) - Postponed activities, especially those involving groups - Trained village child safe agents - Some clients came to meet staff and get services in the office - Applied different methods like online cash transfer - Covid-19 awareness raising with partners, communities, and local authorities
Methods of working, communications and coordination	
- Staff and clients did not feel safe in communities (especially with migrant returnees) and were afraid to meet each other - Staff did not want to work in the office - Staff did not feel good travelling from Phnom Penh to meet partners in the provinces - Network meetings postponed - Communications and activities (like training) done online not as effective as face-to-face - Not enough materials and support, or not on time - Many additional meetings and reports required by FCF|REACT very time-consuming - Inconsistent implementation/expectations of FCF|REACT about reporting - Increased workload for staff to provide case follow-up and required data	- Staff worked from home, had flexible working and rotating schedules to cover the office, and regular leave (some organisations created new staff policies for this to happen) - Ensured staff had all the hygiene protection they needed - Applied strictly MoH protocols for the office, e.g. social distancing and no outside visitors - Online meetings or phone calls: clients/families, local authorities and staff - Provided training online to develop staff capacity to deal with new issues - Provided supportive supervision and increased regular follow up with staff to share information and ways to reduce stress (focus on staff welfare rather than results) - Now have Plan A and Plan B (for working normally and in case Covid-19 still happens) - Cancelled meeting with authorities - More meetings with partners in the network for information sharing (monthly instead of quarterly) - Spent time to study documents and all information sources to understand and know best how to respond and revise plans
Financial	

Challenges	Solutions
- Underspend of project budget - Changing nature of activities increased budget needs - Funding of FCF|REACT was not flexible in the early days - Insufficient funds (and materials) to support communities - Cannot provide the awareness and support to the indirect target groups because of limited budget - Families' income reduced/lost, so needed more budget to support them - High cost of materials purchased for clients - Increased workload, lack of staff, in the project period some budget was underspent, some was overspent, difficult to explain to managers	- Increased budget to staff for using online work arrangements (meeting, contact with client and discuss among team) - In first instance used other donor budget to support for hygiene material for the target group - Allocated budget from another project to use with the project with less money and pay for Zoom - Fund raising: tried to find partners to support materials and awareness raising in communities - Budget revisions for adjustment for Covid-19 protection - Developed an organisational sustainability group for Directors – to help with funding issues.

1.2 Positives arising during the Covid-19 period

As with every complex situation, challenges create opportunities and that was indeed the case during the Covid-19 period. Respondents were readily able to identify what they saw as benefits that had arisen within their organisation and beyond related to their FCF|REACT activities/engagement.



It is notable that so many respondents identified their new understanding and use of technology for multiple purposes as a positive outcome of this period. The next most cited benefit was the multiple types of support received from donors/FCF|REACT/SCI. This included training, follow up, hygiene materials, communication media, and information. Four in this group specifically mentioned getting extra funding. Improved management attention to staff safety was another important group of benefits, and this included ensuring staff knew how to protect themselves, and allowing flexible working from home. This seems to have resulted

in improved staff attitudes and commitment, including more team work, which was also noted a number of times.

(CFI, one of organizations that received PPE and RCCE materials from FCF|REACT / CFI)

Improved relationships, communications and planning with local and national authorities got several mentions, including some that talked about government ownership of the problems and positive responses to help those in need. One respondent noted that provincial level coordination meetings should continue as they had clearly contributed to this improvement.

A few respondents mentioned gaining deeper understanding of target groups and their problems, plus the cross cutting issues, which enabled them to help more and improve child protection in families. Raising awareness about Covid-19, including learning how to do it, was also seen as a benefit by some respondents. Good implementation of the newly introduced cash transfer to clients scheme; working in small groups being more effective than large ones; and, helping parents to learn about supporting and caring for their children, each got just two mentions each.

A long list of other benefits each got just a single mention, and these were: less time spent on travelling; working from home enabled supporting children with online learning; time in the office used to review and update organisational policies; ability to give more care to vulnerable children; increased collaboration with partners; clients not migrating; learning how to adapt; learning how to prioritise; and, that working through village level Child Safe Agents is more sustainable for the long term.

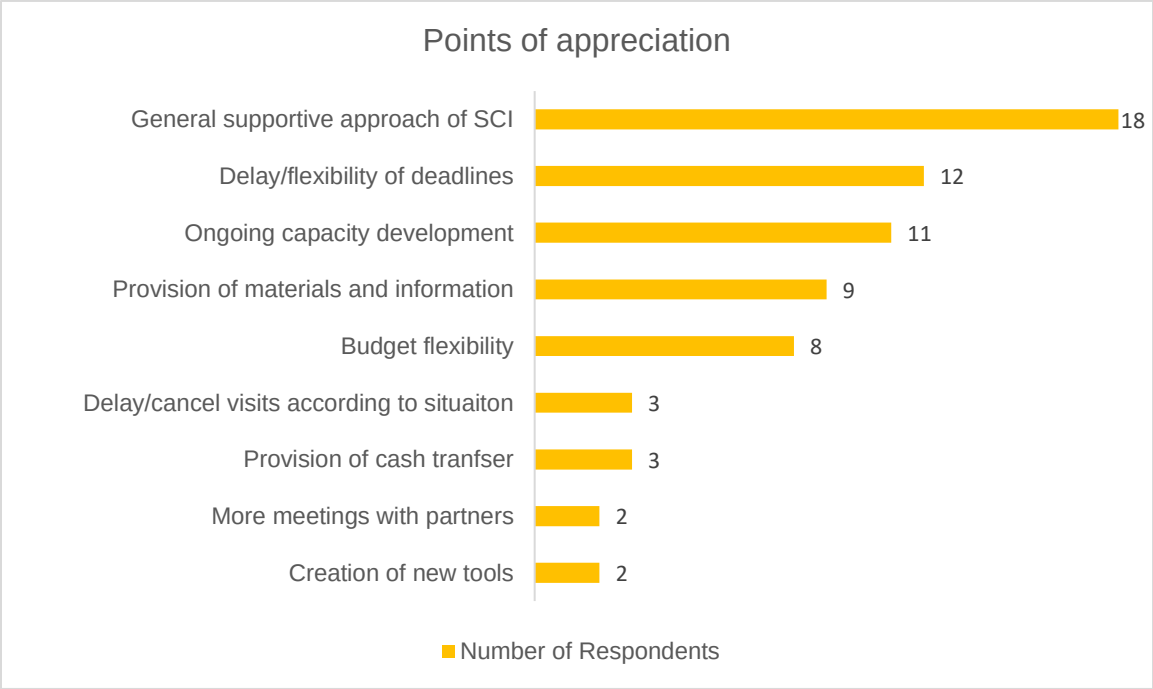
In contrast to what was said about the challenges, one respondent said that child abuse decreased in this period, and another said that fewer clients came to get services at the hospital, though obviously that could be interpreted as a challenge depending on the reasons for the decrease.

For funded partners only

1.3 Changes to procedures and requirements

1.3.1 Appreciated

Virtually all the respondents were appreciative of how FCF|REACT/SCI worked during this period and would want to see the same practices continue if the Covid-19 situation continues or worsens. The first key point of appreciation was the generally supportive approach taken by SCI in being open and flexible, as well as working online for meetings, field visits and other activities. The second key point was deadline flexibility, mostly for reporting, but there were also sometimes mentions of activity flexibility.



In addition to the points in the graph above, increased budget and project extension also got one mention each.

1.3.2 Should have done differently

The only two comments related to what FCF|REACT could have done differently both came from expatriates and both were about the level of additional data collection and reporting required during this period. These respondents both noted that this had created a significant burden, in some cases on field staff, taking them away from activities. One commented that it was still not clear what all this information had been used for as nothing had been shared with partners.

For all partners

1.4 Practical support and information that should be continued

Should the Covid-19 situation continue or worsen, almost all respondents, 26 of 28, would want to see continuation of the support and information given already. One unfunded partner had found the guidelines helpful but appears not to have benefited in any other way. The donor felt that the identification of future needs should come from the partners, not the donor, and therefore did not answer this question.

Protective hygiene materials, information, posters, budget flexibility, capacity development and all other forms of practical support were mentioned many times. Also particularly mentioned by four respondents was the caring emotional support provided by SCI staff. A few people did put particular emphasis on some types of support or the need for more of what they had already been given. For example, four mentioned the need to continue provision of financial support for families through the partners, not just linked to project cycles. Some wanted more visual materials for information sharing in communities. Two wanted more guidance on how to conduct case management in difficult circumstances.

1.5 Practical support and information that was missing?

Two points were raised that had not been mentioned previously. The first was that two respondents specifically mentioned the need to work on strengthening sub-national authority social work capacity and their ability to work with the relevant systems. The second was from a new Director of an unfunded partner who thought that FCF|REACT should provide a clear orientation for unfunded partners about what they can and cannot expect by way of support.

All other answers to this question were simply a repeat of those given to the previous question. Very few appeared to think that anything important was missing, but again, there were some points of emphasis about needing more of something already in place. Over and above the wish for meetings, capacity development, information sharing and such like to continue, the few points of specific emphasis were suggestions to: give more technical support for the cash transfer system; provide support on mental health and counselling for children; provide more information about how other epidemics such as Ebola and SARS have been managed; create and distribute more information materials for communities about the importance of wearing masks; and, more training on the finance systems.

One suggestion beyond the mandate of FCF|REACT, because it belongs with the MoSVY, is to get the reintegration approach fully defined.

1.6 Any other comments about this period?

As with the previous questions, this question raised very few answers that were not a repeat of previous points. The majority simply reiterated their wish for the support to continue. Particular points that were of a different nature were as follows. Two related to the challenges of working online. The first was that if the relationship has not already been established in person, working online deters openness and honesty. The second was related to a concern that if the network membership is extended during a period when online working is the only option, it will be very difficult to integrate new members effectively.

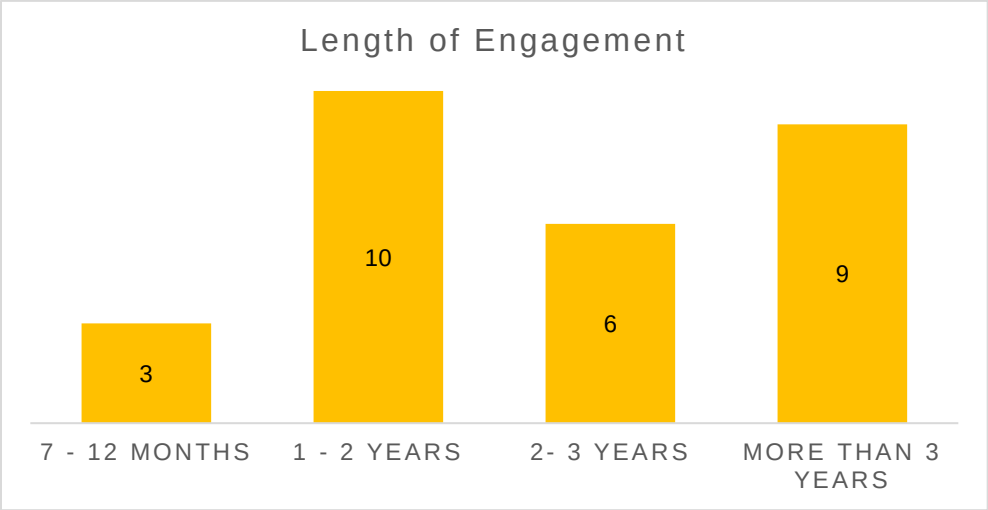
One respondent felt that the cash transfer scheme should be extended to more target groups because some poor families were not eligible. One respondent from a funded partner suggested that SCI having a focal person for each partner would be helpful. The final point was a question about why the network has unfunded partners, and the need to clarify the purpose and potential benefits of their engagement. This was from the person who had expressed frustration about dealings with FCF|REACT which are noted in the answers to other questions.

Implementation period September 2019 – February 2020

Section 2: Overall engagement with FCF|REACT

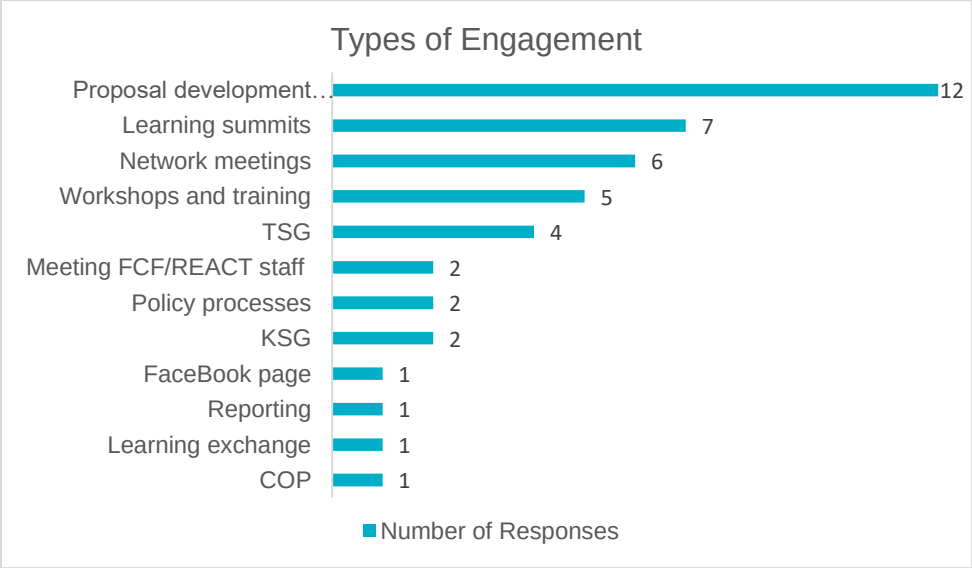
2.1 When did you personally start participating

As the table below shows, the significant majority of respondents have been involved with FCF|REACT for some time. Almost one third (32%) have been involved since the start or early days, more than three years.



2.2 How have you engaged?

It was notable that many of the funded partner respondents tended to focus their answers on recounting their organisation's progress through funding processes i.e. proposal development and sub-grant awards. The unfunded network members did not mention anything about funding processes. This would appear to indicate the high priority funded partners give to the funding relationship relative to other means of engagement with FCF|REACT. The table below sets out the summary of responses.



2.3 Has your level of engagement changed, Why?

While some respondents interpreted this question as being about frequency of engagement, others interpreted it in terms of the depth and quality of engagement, and some mentioned both. In the frequency group six said they were more involved, one person citing the benefits of now being able to join meetings online. Five said their level of engagement was the same, and two said it had reduced, one because another person was also attending for their organisation, and the other cited Covid-19 busyness.

In terms of depth and quality of engagement, 15 respondents mentioned having greater understanding of the project, knowledge of the network, and internal capacity to engage in implementation of activities. Reasons for this improvement were what had been learned from FCF|REACT in various activities, the improved communications and collaboration among partners, and improved relationships with local authorities.

Only one respondent said their level of engagement had stayed the same and no one said it had decreased.

(Cash Transfer Tools training to partners in Battambang, FCF|REACT)

2.4 Would you like to engage in more activities? Which and why?

11 respondents said they would not want to be more engaged in activities, three citing time constraints as the reason, and one citing location. An additional respondent said no unless it was to engage in national level policy development.

The remaining 15 who said they would like to be more engaged in specific FCF|REACT activities offered a wide-ranging list, as follows: four would like more technical support and learning activities; four mentioned policy development/monitoring implementation; and, three would like more learning specifically about disability. The following activities all had just one mention each: know the network better; KSG; capacity development for M&E; research; learning exchange; information sharing; and contribute to training social workers. One expatriate said that in-person activities are preferable because of the networking opportunities they offer. Another expatriate said that small task-based groups are more effective than big meetings for

achieving results, and they would want to engage more at that level. One would like to be more involved if their line manager would allow.
The donor felt the level of engagement was already high and more would be resisted by the partners.

2.5 Would you like to be less engaged? Which activities and why?

A small majority of respondents, 16 in total, said that they would not want to be less engaged, some adding comments about things being 'about right' as they are. One gave a 'no, but' answer which has been included in the yes list below. The other 11 respondents who would like to see less engagement in certain FCF|REACT activities made the following suggestions:

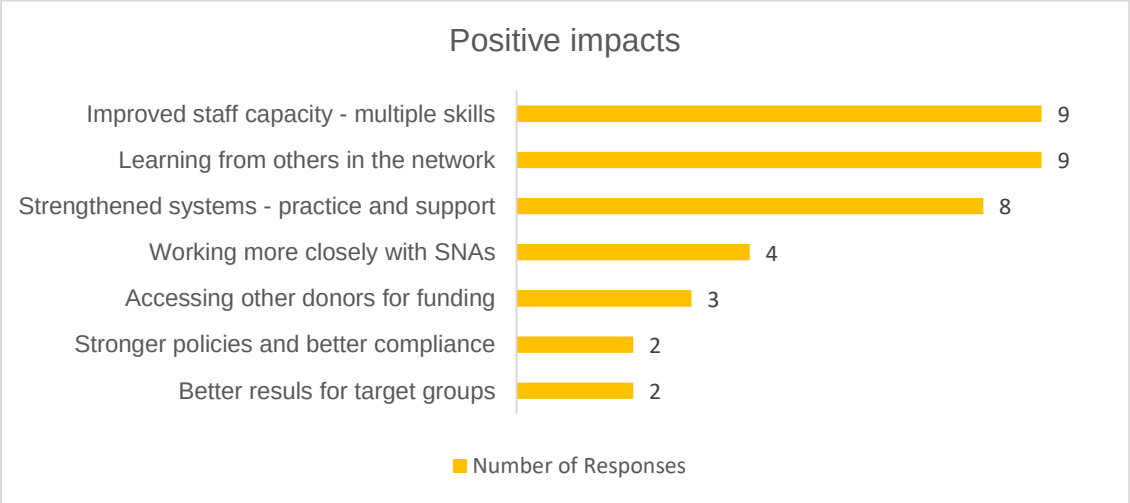
- There were four comments about reducing data requirements and information requests: two partners (one funded, one unfunded) queried what all the data is used for; there was one suggestion to move the data spreadsheet requirement from monthly to quarterly; and one respondent said they needed more staff to complete the data entry requirements
- Three suggested less meetings and/or less time in meetings (more efficient agenda management)
- Two suggested to decrease the time-consuming quarterly visits after year one for well-established partners
- Two respondents want less learning summits
- Two respondents would like less reporting, one specified less financial reporting and the other commented that requirements are '*astronomical*'
- Two would like to see the deadlines for reporting loosened, to be not so tight
- One respondent wanted to have to spend less time explaining things to new staff of SCI
- One respondent said 'too many documents related to Covid-19, if possible, should reduce it'

2.6 How has engagement impacted you or your organization?

This question produced a mixed range of responses. Among the funded partner respondents, some people only noted positive impact, some noted both positive and negative, one noted only negative, and one noted no impact of any sort. The table below shows, the majority of funded partner staff, 21, noted positive impact from being engaged in the network, but seven of them also noted negative impact.

	Positive impact only	Mixed impacts	Negative impact only	No impact
Respondents	14	7	1	1
Organisations	7	5	*Org. included in 'mixed'*	*Org. included in 'mixed'*

The chart below shows the most frequently cited positive points.



Other benefits that had only single mentions included: improved accountability to donors; learning to deal with complex challenges; one voice for the sector; ability to contribute to national policy; support from SCI experts; more focus on disability within the network; and, being engaged in the design of the next phase.

Eight staff from the funded partners raised some negative impacts. Two in particular were very critical of SCI feedback mechanisms, stating that they found themselves dealing with multiple people asking repeated detailed questions, indicating to them that there was no coordination within SCI for feedback to partners. Another commented that the feedback felt like 'fault finding'. On the issue of reporting and feedback four partners noted the heavy workload expected within a short time frame. One partner commented that procurement in particular is a heavy procedure that takes people away from field work. One commented that a lot of time had been spent resolving the difference between their objectives and those of SCI. For implementation matters there were only two comments. One was about the challenges of dealing with sub-national authorities on the matter of per diem payments. The other was about a village activity which then did not function properly because there was no funding support.

The non-funded partners had very mixed views. Two said they had received no benefits from their engagement. One said they had gained a few useful contacts but nothing else. The fourth was much more positive noting that Khmer staff had attended very helpful training courses offered by FCF|REACT, that had led to them embedding some good systems in the organisation. This respondent was also very positive about the networking opportunities offered by membership.

Section 3: For funded partners only: Partnership with Save the Children

3.1 Frequency of contact

Many respondents gave lists of the type of contact they have with SCI and the reasons for the different types of contact. Ten said very clearly that they felt the frequency of contact was about right. Six more were not so clear in their assessment, but there were no negative points in their comments, so it may be assumed that they also felt the level of contact was appropriate. There were many positive comments about issues such as: visits to partner office; discussions to find solutions to problems; good meetings at national level; SCI staff being available for calls on emergency cases; and, generally a good level of communication.

However, a number of respondents differentiated their assessment of contact between different parts of SCI, i.e. technical support for implementation versus dealings with finance and M&E over reporting and compliance, so some offered both positive and negative assessments.

Seven respondents gave mixed or entirely negative comments that the level of contact was too much. The issues of dissatisfaction they raised are as follows: three respondents mentioned the problems arising from SCI staff turnover; two mentioned multiple people giving feedback; two said generally there were too many meetings and reviews; and, two commented on M&E issues. Two people said that the level of contact had been acceptably high for the Covid-19 period, but would not be in normal times. The following issues had just one mention each: a fault-finding attitude; expectations being different in practice to the written agreement; too many requests for documents; too much contact for the respondent's role; and, too much communication to finalise the budget. One partner suggested again that the level of contact could be reduced after the first year of implementation.

In summary these comments represent five partner organisations that gave entirely positive feedback, six that gave mixed responses, and one that was only negative. In some partners there were differences between the respondents.

3.2 Types of contact to increase – ideal frequency?

Approximately half of the respondents, 12, did not want any increase in frequency of contact because they felt it was already sufficient or too much. A number of comments also addressed the quality or content of contact on subjects that have been mentioned in answer to other questions, so those answers have to been repeated here. Those that did want an increase made the following suggestions. The point about availability to deal with urgent issues was raised by two respondents, all other suggestions were mentioned only once:

- More availability to discuss urgent issues by phone;
- Follow up to training should happen twice a month;
- Bi-annual contact between partner's director and Chief of Party of FCF|REACT for high level check in;
- Quicker responses from SCI, if they can't answer something immediately then they should say so;
- Create a mechanism for feedback more frequently than the annual survey;
- Create a platform for joining with other networks and government meetings;
- Develop joint proposals with partners;
- Have smaller but more purposeful meetings; and,
- Meet face to face once a month

There was also a request for the FCF|REACT membership contact list to be checked and kept up to date.

3.3 Types of contact to decrease – ideal frequency?

While 11 respondents said there was nothing that needed to be decreased, the remaining 12 had suggestions for what they would like to see reduced. This included: the number of people giving feedback on reports for five respondents; less meetings for four respondents; and less monitoring visits for two respondents. Other requests that got just one mention each were: reduce the data spread sheet to quarterly; reduce financial reporting to quarterly; stop reviewing reports that have already been approved; reduce the lengthy delays on responding to questions; reduce delays in providing field visit reports; and reduce the administrative burden.

3.4 New types of contact?

12 respondents answered no to this question. Only two respondents suggested a new type of contact and that was to have social activities linked to meetings so partners could get to know each other better. Suggestions from other respondents were for subjects to be addressed within existing types of contact such as meetings, the sharing of research from other sources, and capacity development activities. The requested subjects for capacity development were good governance, fundraising, gender issues and Excel. One partner wanted SCI to be more active in working with local authorities to explain about FCF|REACT. One asked for field visit recommendations to be given officially by email so the partner has them as a reference.

Two partner staff noted that there used to be a newsletter, and they felt it would be useful to have that reinstated to help partners know what everyone else was doing, and what results were being achieved by the network.

Four respondents answered this question with issues of concern that are already dealt with in the relevant sections of this report, so have not been repeated here.

3.5 What is positive about the funding partnership?

The respondents all noted positive aspects of the funding partnership with SCI. The most commonly mentioned was the capacity development that the partners get from SCI that helps to strengthen them in various ways, both for implementation practice and in their internal functioning. There were 13 mentions of relevant issues such as; providing technical support; doing an assessment and making a plan to fill the gaps; and giving constructive feedback to help improve reports. A related issue that eight respondents mentioned was facilitation of the network that enables sharing and learning among partners, and helps to

access support for clients. The promising practices review and FaceBook page were both mentioned in this context. Five respondents talked about having a good relationship which was open and friendly, with good communications. Two respondents said they value the field visits by SCI staff.

Other positive issues that got only one mention each were: being in the network had helped to support the partners' dealings with government; that SCI do not exert pressure as a donor; the M&E is clear; there is regular follow up; flexibility about budget revisions; SCI accepts partner ideas and initiatives; and the value add of the partnership in enabling disability inclusion.

The overall response was that partners want these positive practices to continue. Also, specifically, there were three requests for an increase in capacity development practices such as exchange visits and learning initiatives like the promising practices review. One respondent asked for more support to solve difficult client problems, and another asked for more support for clients.

3.6 What is challenging about the funding partnership?

While five respondents from 5 different partners said they did not see any challenges in the partnership, a majority of respondents, 18, did. Thus there was one or two respondents from each partner reporting challenges. It is notable that the answers to these questions often repeated issues that had been raised in response to others. These challenges have been grouped together, with the number of mentions for each point given in brackets. The challenges are as follows:

- **Time Issues (8 comments in total)**:
    - SCI reporting deadlines being tight (urgent) with little time allowed for checking or revisions, not respecting that what SCI needs is not the only priority a partner may have (2)
    - The time that partners need to spend on SCI requirements (systems and policies) are much greater than covered in the agreement, partners cannot meet the needs (2)
    - Urgent requests for information (2)
    - Not responding in a timely manner when the partner has an urgent issue to resolve (1)
    - Many requests for meetings (1)
- **SCI staff turnover**: the time it takes for new staff to understand the partner and their work, and the time partner staff have to spend explaining things to them. Advice and requests change from old staff member to the new one. (6)
- **SCI inflexibility (4 comments in total)**:
    - Policy - which results in some partners having difficulty working with partners or government staff (2)
    - Expectations – which places the same demands on small NGOs with few resources to respond, as the big ones who are able to deal with all requirements more easily (2)
- **M&E:** the framework does not fit for all partners, the indicator definitions are not clear, some data is requested 'again and again'. (3)
- **Feedback on reports**: the same issues raised repeatedly by multiple SCI staff (2)
- **Field visits/monitoring visits**:
    - Sometimes SCI staff are not experienced and unable to make decisions/give advice so a delay in getting guidance (1)
    - The follow up report from SCI setting out problems that were not discussed during the visit and thus coming as a surprise for the partner (1)
    - SCI do not advise in advance the agenda for visit so partner unable to prepare (1)
    - SCI are very slow to provide reports after field visits (1)

One partner also mentioned that as a small NGO they did not feel confident that they could cope with the extra work if there was a further Covid-19 outbreak.

Four respondents proposed some solutions to the challenges they experience, as follows:

- Manage requests for reports and information in ways that give partners more time to respond, be more flexible with deadlines

- Respond in more timely manner to partners needs
- Explain more clearly why information is being requested and how it will be used (for the benefit of partners and clients)
- Ensure proper handover between old and new staff at SCI
- Have clear procedures and protocols for providing feedback to partners about observed problems
- Be willing to be flexible on policy and expectations
- Have more, smaller meetings to resolve specific issues, especially challenges with government
- Try to be more relational than transactional in the approach to problems

3.7.a Staff support and behavior

Respect: 16 partner staff answered with an unqualified yes, that SCI staff show respect to the partners. Seven gave 'yes, but' answers, indicating that they had mixed experiences in that some staff show respect in the relationship, but others do not. This they noted as showing in behaviours such as not accepting the partner's comments, or not bothering to respond to communications. Two respondents noted specific behaviours, one was that the cash transfer team 'acts as supervisor', and the other was that the M&E team are seen to put compliance above all else.

Helpful: All except two respondents said that they found the SCI staff helpful, many commenting on good support to solve problems. One negative comment was about recommendations that did not fit to the partner's circumstances, and another noted 'if they come to support, make sure it really is support'.

Capable: 18 respondents gave an unqualified yes to this question. The technical knowledge and expertise of SCI staff is well appreciated. Four respondents gave 'yes, but' answers, mostly indicating that problems arise when the SCI staff do not know the partner organisation and its work well enough to give relevant advice or inputs. One comment was about M&E staff not understanding concepts of child protection. One respondent was new to the network and did not feel able to answer this question.

Quick and fair problem solving: Just over half of the respondents, 12, gave an unqualified yes to this question. Nine gave 'yes but' answers, seven of whom cited time delays as the reason for their answer, the other two mentioned unfairness in funding decisions. The two respondents who gave no answers to this question both said the SCI takes 'a long time' to resolve issues.

3.7.b Changes in support since started working with FCF|REACT

The majority of the changes noted by respondents were positive, and were in relation to what they perceived to be improvements in their internal capacity as a result. The most noted positive change, by 12 respondents, was about improved (clearer) documentation and systems for donor compliance, M&E tools and implementation procedures. Three respondents mentioned they now get more support to get funding for clients. Two mentioned improved communications, and two mentioned support within the network. Other improvements that got one mention each were: giving feedback on field visits; study visits; being able to influence at the national level; and quicker information sharing.

The only comments made about the future were to the effect that these positive changes should continue, plus one request to provide more capacity development for partners and social workers in relevant departments. There was also one request was for increased funding.

There was only one negative change noted and it is not clear that this is in fact a change. One respondent raised the issue of inflexibility on budget expenditure. They suggested that partners should be allowed to make purchases in the provinces to avoid the current long delays in getting responses from SCI.

(A household receiving additional support through the cash transfer program in BTB, CCT)

Section 4: FCF|REACT network engagement

4.1 Ability to contribute and participate

All except one respondent gave positive answers about their ability to contribute to and participate in the network either fully or substantively. Four of those respondents gave qualified answers related to the availability of their time, and one mentioned language constraints preventing full participation.

By far the most important reason given about why respondents found engagement positive was the learning and capacity development that came from sharing experiences and information together, mentioned by 13 respondents. Four mentioned improved communications and collaboration between partners. Four also mentioned being able to train and contribute their good practices for others to learn from. Being able to access services for clients and joining proposal development processes were each mentioned twice. Other reasons that respondents found participation positive were: having meetings/events online now encourages participation; it promotes the partner's work with others; and partnership will strengthen the network. Interestingly one respondent said they were confident to participate in Khmer, which was in contrast with the one mentioned above who said that too much English inhibited their participation.

Two respondents suggested that they would like to contribute more as they feel they have something useful to offer. Two funded expatriates expressed the view that the bigger meetings are less effective and much more can be achieved by smaller meetings, some of which should be in the provinces to enhance the local networks.

(A participant engaging with the Co-Design Workshop, held in Feb 2021 / FCF|REACT)

4.2 Challenges to contributing and participating

Ten respondents said they did not have any challenges in contributing or participating. For the others the challenges noted were many and varied. Four respondents mentioned the challenge of a lot of English language in meetings and training, and one added that the translation into Khmer is not strong. Three respondents said they were too busy and did not have enough staff to participate in everything offered. Three mentions were made about meetings having a big agenda, too many participants and not enough time to deal with things fully. Two respondents, both expatriate, said that open processes get bogged down and sometimes the situation just needs someone to make a decision. Many other reasons got a single mention each, including – too much travelling time involved, short notice and no clear schedule for meetings, low confidence to participate, and some partners are defensive about sharing. Two expatriates, one funded and one unfunded, said that they found online participation increasingly difficult to engage with as for them there is so much greater value in face-to-face networking.

The suggestions offered for overcoming the challenges were: have more of the meetings in Khmer; have more efficient planning – send out the agenda at least a week ahead; and, arrange a means of online information sharing for those who cannot attend meetings.

4.3 Extent to which the network draws on members

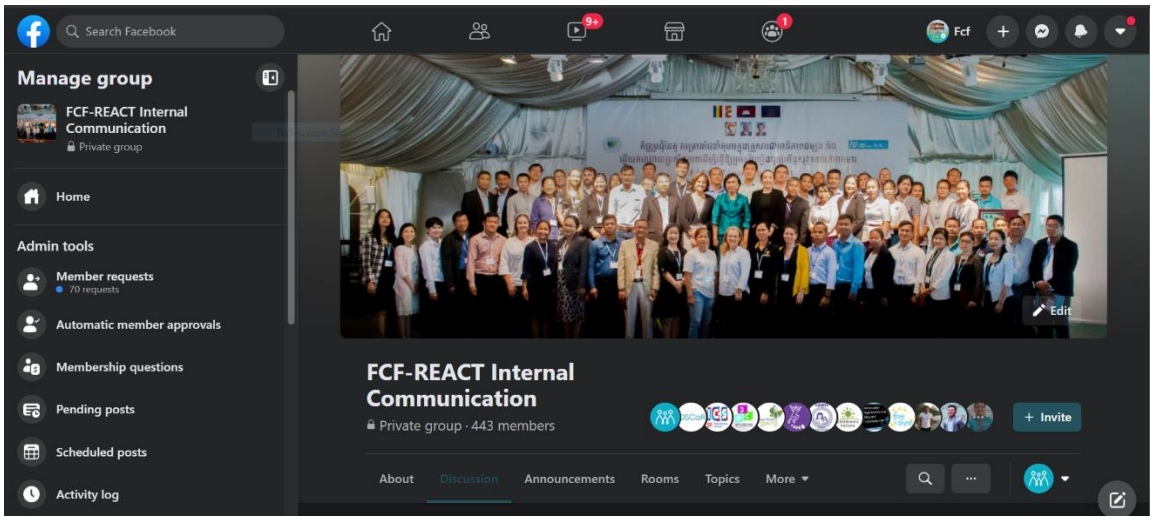
While 25 of the 28 respondents answered this question, there were few comments that were different to those given in 4.1. Almost all responses reiterated what members view as being of value about the network and why. A few commented on what they had contributed, for example a promising practice review example.

None of the Cambodian respondents commented on the extent to which the network draws on its members. However, expatriates did offer some comments. One said that it was a yes and no answer, because their organisation did feel able to contribute, but there were also missed opportunities to have them share experiences. Another said they could do more, but recognised that there is a need to find the right balance

as funded and unfunded members of the network would have different levels of interest. Two, one a funded long-time partner and one unfunded and new, both said that they did not think their expertise was recognised or valued as they have never been asked to contribute anything.

4.4 Useful information and support, positive practices

The first part of this question was closed, and all respondents answered yes. Their comments on the additional questions were multiple mentions of email, Telegram, the FaceBook page, documents on the website, and phone calls. All of which were generally regarded as satisfactory. However one respondent said there are too many emails, sometimes repetitive of the same information. Another, while noting positively that FCF|REACT did share important documents, also said they were not active enough in doing so.



(FCF|REACT Internal Facebook group, a platform to share information among the network members)

4.5 What information and support is missing?

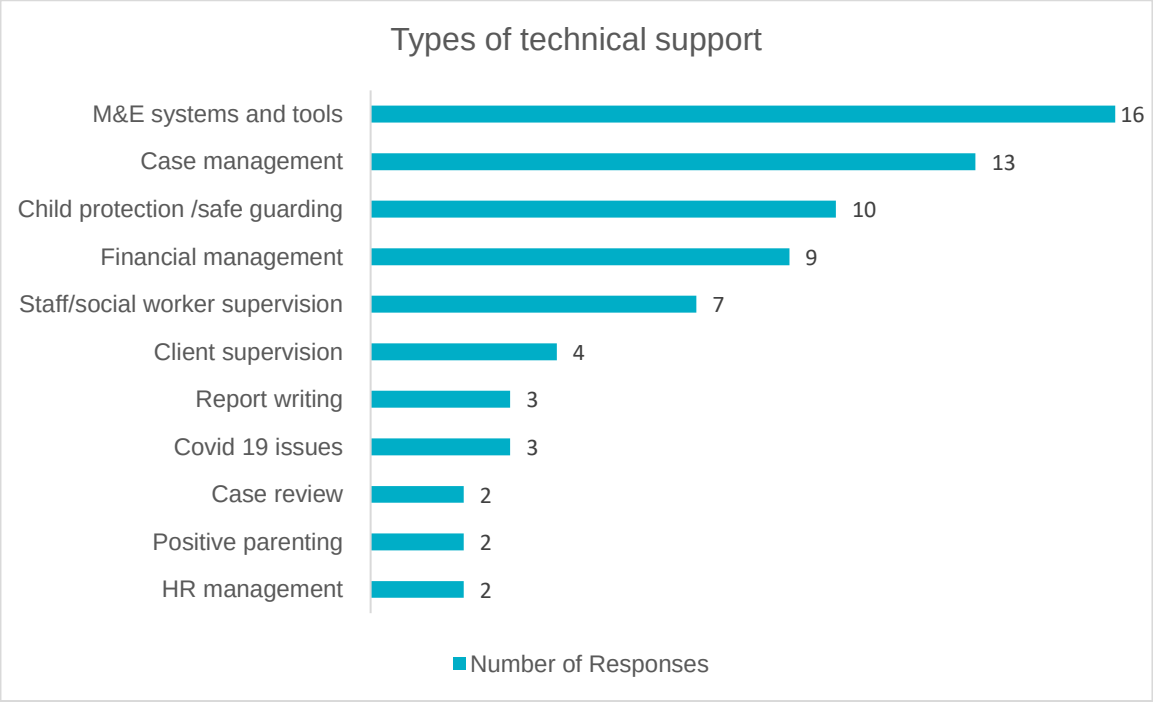
Over half of the respondents, 15, said that nothing more is needed. There were, however, some requests about what partners would like to see put in place. Three respondents want more information on national documents, standards, policies etc. This request was both for child protection matters, and for government legislation on issues like tax and employment law, maybe in the form of a central data base or a bi-annual update. The other points, each mentioned just once, were as follows:

- Clear information for selection criteria for funding, and a proposal for a concept note for co-design of projects;
- More activity on the FaceBook page;
- A mechanism for feedback and more two-way communications;
- A core information map about the partners and members so everyone can know who is doing what in each province;
- Interesting short videos on best practices in the resources section of the website;
- More face-to-face meetings, socially distanced of course;
- Reports on the field visits done with their organisation;
- A quarterly fact sheet update on achievements in the network (i.e. share the results of all the M&E inputs partners provide); and,
- Publish the partner survey results and show how they are going to be used.

Section 5: Organizational support, best practices and challenges

5.1 Types of technical support and related changes

The respondents all noted multiple types of technical support they have received from FCF|REACT. The types of support with multiple mentions are shown in the graph below.



Child reintegration, procedure to request adoption, policy gaps, code of conduct and mental health support for children and adults also each had just one mention. The methods of receiving this technical support were described as: training, study visits, coaching during field visits, quarterly visits, exchange of expertise/specialisms with FCF|REACT, practice documents, advice and guidance for problem solving, and visit to check process compliance.

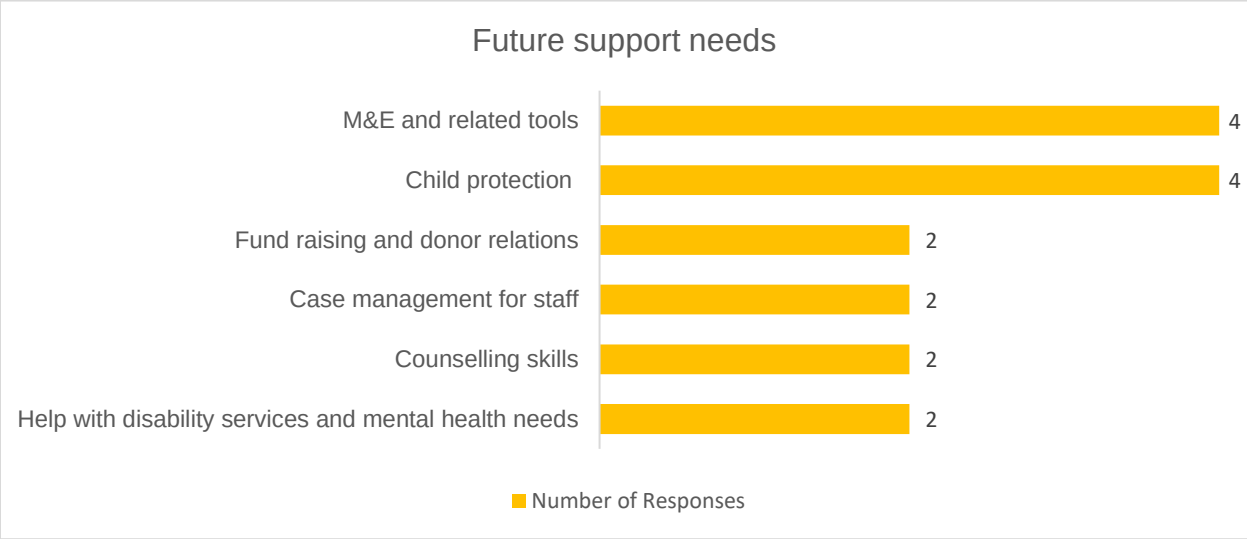
All partners who had received support had found it to be useful, resulting in positive changes. These included both improved practice, particularly in case management, and strengthened organisational systems.

Two unfunded members said that they had not received any technical support.

5.2 What type of technical support will your organization need in future?

The answers to this question were wide ranging, and even though the full question stressed being specific some respondents did not give clear answers, only suggestions such as ‘training on project subjects’, ‘relevant knowledge’, ‘the same as we get now’. One funded and one unfunded partner said they did not need technical support from FCF|REACT in future.

The subjects requested multiple times are:



One of the requests for M&E was to take it to a higher impact level.

All other subjects were mentioned just once:

- Finance management
- Help with Ministry registration
- Information when RGC issues new *Prakas* or other guiding documents
- Leadership development
- LGBT issues
- Management systems
- Organisation development needs
- Positive parenting training
- Providing supervision to staff
- Quarterly technical support field visits, not only to the office
- Refresher training on the subjects already offered
- Repeat supervision and positive parenting training for new staff
- See what others are doing on income generation training
- Training for sub-national authorities and social workers
- Working with child victims

5.3 Implementation of recommendations from the last survey

5.3.a Meetings: location, management, translation

All respondents agreed this recommendation had been implemented, but some changes had happened as a result of, and necessitated by, Covid-19 precautions. There was one comment about the difficulty of controlling online meetings.

Twelve respondents noted that translation is available in meetings, but half of those said it needs to be improved. The main concern was that translators need more knowledge of the subjects. One respondent suggested that the discussion of complex issues should have consecutive, not simultaneous, translation. There was also a suggestion that more documents should be translated into Khmer.

5.3.b Quarterly Learning Exchange Visits and Community of Practices

While 14 respondents gave answers that were generally positive that this had been implemented, half of them qualified their answer with comments that these activities have not been happening since Covid-19

precautions started. The remaining 13 respondents said that they did not know about, or thought this recommendation has not been implemented.

5.3.c Finance team: Improved communications and problem solving

A significant majority, 19 of the respondents said without reservation that yes, this recommendation has been implemented. Three said it has not been implemented, all citing time and delays in procedures and getting decisions. One respondent felt unable to comment as not directly involved in finance matters. The question was not relevant for five of the respondents.

5.3.d Limit changes to M&E indicators

14 respondents agreed without further comment that this recommendation has been implemented. Five said implementation is in process but is not yet good, or fully resolved, as clarifications are still needed. Two said they did not think this had been implemented. One said that there were a lot of new indicators to the Covid-19 period, which had been 'painful'. One did not know as new to the organisation. The question was not relevant for five of the respondents.

5.3.e Ensure members/partners have knowledge of others

Without further comment 14 said this recommendation has been implemented. Six agreed there has been some implementation, but qualified their answers with comments such as 'partners know about the work about 60%'. Seven said there had been no implementation. Several respondents in the latter two groups pointed out that it is difficult for new members or incoming personnel (especially if unfunded) to get to know other members, or about the network and what is being done and achieved. One response was that it has been hard to deal with this during the Covid-19 period.

5.3.f Partners have a capacity development plan

Of the 23 respondents from the funded partners, 13 said said this recommendation has been implemented, and one said it had been implemented, but added negative comments about the implementation. Five said it had not been implemented, one of whom noted that they were a new partner, so the assessment had not yet been conducted. Four respondents were not clear if anything had been done or not.

5.3.g Fostering interpersonal relationships

While the majority of Cambodian respondents to this question said that implementation had been achieved in full or in part, it must be noted that this is a contradiction of some responses to other questions, which indicate that there are still some issues that are in need of attention.

Among the expatriate respondents the views expressed were very different. Some feel that the relationships they have are appropriate for their role, noting that most usually they are dealing with other expatriates. But more than one noted that they hear about challenges for the Cambodian staff in their organisation to deal with the Khmer staff of SCI. Newcomers, especially in the unfunded members, do not feel that they have any relationship with FCF|REACT.

Summary of the overall comments about the recommendations

While very few respondents said they thought that everything had been implemented, the general view is that there has been some progress on the recommendations, but they are not yet fully implemented. There were suggestions that there should be regular reviews at every FCF|REACT meeting, and also in meetings between SCI staff and individual partner organisations, because the plans are sometimes in place but not being actioned. Several mentioned the need to refresh understanding of what is set out in the partner agreement.

5.4 Recommendations from respondents

The respondents had many recommendations related to all the issues covered in the survey, and beyond. Some had been mentioned previously in other sections that asked for suggestions for solutions to challenges. As the recommendations offered are so many and wide-ranging, they have been grouped into five subjects in order to present them according to key themes. Where the same or very similar issue was raised by more than one respondent the comments have been consolidated and the number in brackets at the end of each point is the number of times the issue was mentioned by respondents. No number in brackets indicates that the recommendation was made just once.

Network relationships
- Remind all members of the goals of the network and take action with inactive members. It still feels like there are 10 separate projects and it isn't clear how it is connecting into a coordinated child protection system. Support and facilitation of more collaboration between member organisations would help with this. Small organisations can't do it without specific support. Add objectives into the framework about process, not only product, to really make the network and collaboration the key issue as this is essential for long term sustainability. (4) - Map the members and identify their strengths in order to ensure they have stronger voice at national level and also their potential to contribute and support others. (2) - Ensure when selecting partners they are a match with FCF|REACT goals. - Link to other networks working for benefit of children. - Make a statement explaining what it means to be an unfunded partner, what the expectations are and what the access is – currently nothing is clear to new incomers.
Learning and capacity development mechanisms
- General comments about the need to continue assessing, encouraging and strengthening the capacity of partners through the exisiting mechanisms like learning summits and exchange visits. Also general comments like 'provide new subjects'. (7) - Organize more exchange and study visits between partners in order to share learning, experiences and skills. Extend exchange visits to one week, so people can get real depth of understanding about others' practices rather than a simple orientation. (2) - Share the findings from the pilots to enable learning that will support sustainability after external funding ceases.
Communications, meetings and other information issues
- Improve meeting efficiency and shift the focus in meetings to contributions from Khmer staff, they are too much led by foreigners. (4) - Have events, learning summits, etc. rotate around the provinces, not always in Phnom Penh. This will enhance engagement with provincial sub-national authorities. Do more of other types of meetings at provincial level to get local partners better connected as this is more effective. (2) - Provide more general transparency and information sharing about the overall achievements of FCF|REACT. This could include quarterly data updates on where things are with reintegration and general monthly progress update on the website. (2) - Get more documentation translated into Khmer to make it accessible for Cambodian staff - Provide more information on key topics. - Reduce the number of meetings
FCF|REACT/SCI - partner relationships
- Allow/continue some flexibility for implementation, reporting and budgeting, don't stick so strictly to policy. (5)

- Improve transparency generally, and specifically about partner selection and decision making about who receives funding (there is one comment that some partners seem to get selected before announcements are made). (4)
- Accelerate response rate to partners, including turnaround of feedback on reports. (2)
- Make sure when there is staff turnover there is full handover and orientation for incoming staff, don't leave it to the partner to keep explaining to new staff. (2)
- Act like a partner, be flexible and supportive, don't be so donor driven.
- Each partner should have one focal point person in SCI. If not possible, then before giving feedback consolidate information and internal agreement, and have just one person communicate with the partner. (2)
- Each provincial program coordinator should have more understanding of all partners.
- Reduce the number of meetings with partner staff, they are busy with field work.
- Have an annual feedback mechanism with individual partners to build the relationship, see the progress, changes and gaps for the improvement of the partner.

Project implementation

- Continue to provide both technical and finance support so partners can support children's families.
- Provide more funding and support the partners to do fundraising.
- Support community empowerment activities.
- Accompany partners on field visits to beneficiaries
- More promotion and materials for work on disability and inclusion.
- Consider working with indigenous peoples.
- Extend to more provinces.

5.5 Anything else to add

Only 10 respondents chose to add anything in response to this question. Each offered just one comment, as follows:

- There is a need to strengthen collaboration to encourage all members and partners and break down competition for funding.
- A request to provide more training.
- A request for continued funding support, because families and children still need support, especially during Covid-19 issue. One partner is worried about whether they performed well enough to get another round of USAID funding.
- A question was asked about what SCI thinks about partners' staff wellbeing.
- The feedback should be two-way. There is a lot of feedback partners could get from FCF|REACT about what they are doing well, but importantly what they can do to improve. Make it more of a partnership that involves partners fixing things too, not just this survey assessing SCI's work.
- There are some enormous strengths and challenges in being part of the network, but there are also some big challenges that come with this level of programme, i.e. addressing a complex issue and working with multiple partners.
- An unfunded partner noted that there was no handover at the time of taking over, so no information was given about FCF|REACT, and it has not been provided since by the network.
- Another unfunded partner said that in general for them it has been overall positive – it has its frustrations, but there is enough benefit to stay involved. The biggest benefit is the connection with other members in the network.
- One partner organisation needs a lot of high-quality social workers – capacity development and retention is a big issue for them.
- It would be good to have the voice of social workers in this survey.

Annex 1: Interview questionnaire

Key Informant Interviews
Informant information

1. Name:
2. Organization:
3. Gender:
   - Male
   - Female
   - Other
4. Nationality:
   - Khmer
   - Expatriate
5. Relationship to FCF|REACT/ Role in your organization:
   - Technical advisor/program management in FCF|REACT Member
   - Senior management in FCF|REACT Member
   - Donor

Implementation period March 2020 onwards : Covid-19 issues
Intro to section: This first series of questions is to capture feedback on engagement and support during the COVID-19 period (March 2020 onwards), as we understand the exceptional nature of .this period

1. What did you find to be the major challenges arising in the Covid-19 period related to your ?FCF|REACT activities? What steps did you take to address the challengs
2. Did anything positive arise in the COVID-19 period related to your FCF|REACT ?activities/engagement

:**For funded partners**

3. In what ways did FCF|REACT change procedures and requirements during the Covid-19 period? ?Did you find these changes appropriately flexible and supportive
   - .If yes, please explain what you appreciated
   - .If no, please explain what you would have like FCF|REACT to have done differently

For all partners:

4. Overall, in what ways do you think FCF|REACT/Save the Children provided practical support and information to your organization during COVID-19 that should be continued should the COVID-19 situation persist or worsen?
5. Overall, what important practical support and information was missing that FCF|REACT/Save the Children should address if the COVID-19 situation persists or worsens?
6. Are there any other comments you would like to make about the impact of COVID-19 on your organization or on the relationship with your organization and FCF|REACT/Save the Children during the COVID-19 period that you haven't already covered?

Implementation period September 2019 – February 2020 (pre-covid, routine/normal FCF|REACT (engagement

Intro to section: The remaining questions seek to understand your pre-covid, typical engagement in FCF|REACT. As we are hopefully entering a "new normal" period, it is important for us to capture

feedback and information that will help us improve the routine/normal implementation of the FCF|REACT .network

Overall Engagement with FCF|REACT

1. When did you (personally) start participating in FCF|REACT?
2. In which ways have you engaged with FCF|REACT?
3. Has your individual level of engagement in FCF|REACT activities changed since you personally started participating in FCF|REACT? In what ways has it changed and why?
4. Would you like to be more engaged in certain FCF|REACT activities? If yes, which activities and what is needed to support your engagement?
5. Would you like to be less engaged in certain FCF|REACT activities? If yes, which activities and why?
6. In what ways has your engagement impacted (or not) you individually as well as the organization you work for?

Partnership with Save the Children (for funded partners only) -

1. How would you rate the frequency of contact you personally have had with Save the Children on your sub-award agreement (too little, just right, too much)? Please explain your response.
2. Are there certain types of contact that you would like to see increase? If yes, for each type of contact what would be the ideal frequency?
3. Are there certain types of contact you would like to see decrease? If yes, for each type of contact what would be the ideal frequency?
4. Are there any new or additional types of contact that you would like to have from Save the ?Children
5. In what ways (if any) do you feel your funding partnership with Save the Children and relationship with its staff is positive? Why do you see these as positive? Which positive practices you would like to see Save the Children build on?

6. In what ways (if any) do you feel your funding partnership with Save the Children and relationship with its staff is challenging? Why do you see these as challenging? How do you think Save the Children should address these challenges?

7. *Additional question if not already covered in above two questions:*

    a. How would you rate Save the Children staff support and behaviour towards you and your organisations:
        i. Do they show respect in the relationship?
        ii. Are they helpful?
        iii. Are the capable?
        iv. Are they able to solve issues quickly and fairly?
    b. Do you feel the support has changed (positively and/or negatively) since you started working with FCF|REACT? In what ways? Are there practices that Save the Children should continue and/or change to support this?

FCF|REACT network engagement: participation, information and support

1. How well do you feel you are positively able to both contribute to, and participate in, the FCF|REACT network? Why do you see these as positive? Are there positive practices you would like to see FCF|REACT build on?
2. In what ways (if any) do you feel it is challenging to both contribute to, and participate in, the FCF|REACT network? Why do you see these as challenging? How do you think FCF|REACT could address these challenges?

3. *:If not answered in questions 1 and 2*
    a. To what extent do you feel that FCF|REACT utilizes and draws upon the strengths and knowledge of its members? Do you feel they recognize your expertise and value your inputs?
4. Do you feel that you or your organization receives information and support that is useful to your organization? What FCF|REACT mechanisms do you feel support this? Are there positive practices you would like to see FCF|REACT build on?
5. In what ways (if any) do you feel you or your organization has not received information and support that is useful to, or required by, you/your organization? In what ways do you think that FCF|REACT should address this?

Organizational support, best practices and challenges

1. What kind of technical support have you/ your organization received from FCF|REACT? Do you feel this technical support met your/ your organization's needs? Has it led to system/practice changes within your organization? Why/why not?
2. What kind of technical support do you/ your organization need in the future from FCF|REACT? Please be as specific as possible. Why would this technical support be useful/ required by you/ your organization?
3. As a result of the last partner survey/KII process, FCF|REACT has tried to implement a number of recommendations related to:
    a. The location, planning and management of meetings and events including language and translation, and use of technology for remote participation
    b. That there be quarterly Learning Exchange Visits and Community of Practices
    c. More effective ways of communication from FCF|REACT finance team, quicker resolution of issues and explanation of why information is important.
    d. Limit changes to M&E indicators where possible, or if changes are necessary, ensure partners are aware and equipped to collect additional data.
    e. Ensure FCF|REACT members/partners understand the work and areas of expertise of other members/partners and how they contribute to FCF|REACT common goals.
    f. Partners having a capacity development plan, based on their SCI partner assessment, to strategically and systematically address any gaps.
    g. Fostering and maintaining interpersonal relationships between FCF|REACT team and partners, despite changes in staffing in the FCF|REACT team.

    - How well do you feel FCF|REACT has implemented these recommendations? Are there positive practices you would like to see FCF|REACT build on? What could FCF|REACT do differently to further address these recommendations?
4. What recommendations do you have for improving the FCF|REACT network? Please be specific. How do you think FCF|REACT should address these recommendations?
5. Is there anything else you wanted to talk about/ mention today that we have not covered?

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